

LESKO?HELP

BRAND & DESIGN SYSTEM

DON'T GIVE UP.

Somebody will answer. That is the promise,
and everything in this system exists to make
it believable.



WHAT THIS IS

This is the Lesko Help brand system as it stands today. It is a **working draft**, not a finished manual — several sections are settled, several are explicitly open, and the open ones are marked so nobody mistakes a proposal for a decision.

Everything here was built from real evidence: the community itself, the existing Quick Guides, Matthew's own words, and the assets already in use. Where something was invented rather than found, it says so.

THE ONE RULE FOR USING THIS DOCUMENT

A section marked **SETTLED** can be used without asking. A section marked **OPEN** must not be treated as decided — ask first. Never invent a value for an open section.

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09	Asset specs — every community surface	Settled
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THE STORY

A brand is a world people enter, not a look. Every design decision in this document is downstream of what follows.

The villain — there are two

The hidden door

Money that is legally yours, sitting behind forms, jargon, and the belief that it isn't for people like you. This is Matthew's own founding observation:

I got bored of helping fat cats after a while and thought, why doesn't everyone know this information?

And its parasite

People who charge for what is free — including impersonators who pose as Matthew or his team to rob the members he is trying to help. This is not hypothetical: members of this community have lost real money to a fake "USAID Grant Administrator" and then been asked for thousands more.

THE STRONGEST SENTENCE THE BRAND OWNS

Your subscription is all the money he will ever ask for.

What is at stake

The house on Friday. The car that keeps the job. The procedure Medicare won't cover. Not abstractions — the actual things members write about when they arrive.

The main character

Someone who has been told no so many times they have started saying it to themselves. The word they use about themselves is **desperate**. The word they are afraid of is **stupid**. Often older, often disabled, often caring for somebody else, frequently writing from a phone — and sometimes with no phone at all.

They write in fragments. Real posts, unedited: *"How do I get money."* · *"I'm so confused on how to navigate."* · *"I need help finding any grant I can apply for before I give up."*

The guide

Matthew Lesko. Eighty-two. Eccentric on purpose. Members call him **Mr. Question Man** — a name they gave him, not one he took. He is the only figure in this category who never asks for more money.

The practice

Asking. He does not write your grant for you — he teaches you to ask, which is what the question mark has meant all along. The costume was never a gimmick; it is the thesis.

The promise

 *Don't give up. Somebody will answer.*

Note what this promise is not. It is not "get rich". It is not a guaranteed amount. The emotional truth of a win, in this community, is not the size of the cheque — it is that **somebody finally answered**. Design and copy should feel like a hand raised, never like a sales page.

VOICE

The brand's own phrases were not written by marketing. They grew in the community, and members repeat them to each other unprompted. Use these; do not invent replacements.

Don't give up. Ever.

Stay safe out there.

It was right on time.

How to write

- Short sentences. One idea per line.
- Plain words. If a member would have to look it up, replace it.
- Write at the level people actually write to us — fragments and all.
- Say the thing. No wind-up, no cleverness.

Never

- Hype, urgency countdowns, or the word "secrets"
- Anything implying government affiliation
- Guaranteed outcomes or guaranteed amounts
- Invented dollar figures — real and sourced, or bracketed as [AMOUNT]

VOCABULARY

These names were found in use, not invented. Use them exactly.

The Grant Roadmap — seven steps, in order

1	Daily Welcome Tour
2	Call Sheet Classes
3	AI Grant Researcher
4	Questions Channel
5	Application Classes
6	Group Coaching
7	Ask Matthew Live

The roadmap is the spine of the member journey. It should look identical everywhere it appears — in the community, in a guide, in an email — so that a member who can barely read still recognises where they are.

Proper nouns

Navigators	Member guides who run live sessions. Stipended.
LeskoHelpers	What members call themselves
Mr. Question Man	Matthew. Member-given, and worth protecting.
Quick Guide Library	The printable resource guides
Success Stories	Where wins are posted
Safety Warnings	Scam alerts
We Care	—
Thursday Drop-In Clinic	Weekly open session
Lesko Pro	The business hub
My Grant Buddy	The member-facing AI companion

THE CHARACTER

Matthew is the brand's guide, and the illustrated version of him is its most valuable asset — because it is the one thing an impersonator cannot copy.



The canonical reference stills. Every new image descends from one of these.

Three forms, three jobs

FORM	WHERE IT IS USED	WHY
Illustrated Matthew	The guide inside the product — roadmap steps, guides, thumbnails, teaching, wayfinding	Ownable, reproducible, accessible, impossible to counterfeit
Real photo and video	Proof of a living person — live sessions, testimonials, "this is really him"	Authenticity and warmth
AI-generated photoreal	Never	It is precisely what the impersonators produce

That last row is a hard rule, not a preference. In a category whose live enemy is people faking Matthew to rob members, publishing convincing fake photographs of him is the wrong instinct — it is the scammer's own register.

Generating him — the rules that matter

Full detail lives in the repository. Three rules cause every failure when broken:

1. **Never generate from text alone.** Always attach a reference still. The originals were never generated from a prompt — they were made elsewhere from real photographs

and brought in as files. A generation with an empty reference slot invents a new man every time.

2. **Never ban his features.** Banning spiky hair, bared teeth, wide eyes or sharp features deletes the character — those *are* Matthew. A prompt built on those bans produced a generic soft grandfather who wasn't him at all.
3. **Never write his real name in a prompt.** He is a real public figure; naming him makes image models refuse or quietly degrade the result. Describe by attributes only.

THE RULE THAT FIXES THE UNSETTLING FACE

Wild hair and a big open laugh are not the problem. Unsmiling eyes are. A wide-open mouth with flat, staring eyes reads as menacing. The same open mouth with crinkled eye corners, lifted cheeks and raised brows reads as charming. Keep every energetic trait and specify the eyes.

Proportions and framing

Matthew is tall and lean — drawn at roughly eight heads, with legs slightly more than half his height and a small head relative to the body. He is never short, stocky or big-headed.

Full-body poses need a 2:3 portrait frame. A wide pose in a square frame forces the figure to be scaled down to fit, and short legs are the result regardless of how the proportions are worded. Square is only for chest-up crops — which is what the original stills are, and why they never had this problem.

THE WARDROBE

Each costume is a signal, not decoration — so the right Matthew carries the right message before a word is read.

COSTUME	SHIRT	JOB
Yellow , black question marks	Black, multicoloured polka dots	Welcome & everyday. The signature.
Blue , white question marks	Black, multicoloured hearts	Teach & explain — roadmap, classes, guides
Green , yellow question marks	Black, multicoloured polka dots	Celebrate — Success Stories, wins

Hearts under the teaching suit are deliberate: teaching is the caring act in this brand. He doesn't lecture, he helps.

Wardrobe rules

Each of these was learned from an image that was rejected.

- **The motif is always question marks** — never blocks, confetti or abstract shapes. The print varies by colour and ground, never by shape.
- **The shirt ground is always black**, with large flat shapes in brand colours and bold black outlines. Never a plain white shirt — it reads corporate instantly.
- **The shirt is never plainer than the suit.** He does not do quiet underneath.
- **Nothing corporate below the neck** — no neckties, no bow ties, no plain black belt. Belts are coloured.
- **One print per costume.** The print is part of how a costume is recognised.

Tried and not adopted

Orange

He wears it in real photographs, but orange sits between yellow (attention) and red (danger) — the two most safety-critical signals the brand owns — and would blur exactly the distinction that must never blur.

The multicoloured confetti suit

A real garment and a good one, but its print is an intricate irregular photographic pattern that flat comic style cannot reconstruct from a written description. It would need a photograph of the actual suit as a second reference image.

A dedicated Protect costume

Attempted in dark navy and in red; both rejected. The dark version also dropped his laugh, which made him read as cold.

OPEN

There is still no costume for **scam warnings and safety** — and it may be the wrong question. A warning might be better served by yellow Matthew beside a red warning graphic than by dressing him for bad news. To decide deliberately, not by default.

The yellow-suit tension, resolved

Yellow is both his signature suit and the "pay attention" colour. If both, the signal weakens. The resolution: **the yellow suit is identity, not signal**. The attention role belongs to yellow *surfaces* — highlighter bars, callout blocks, ink on yellow. Suit and surface do different jobs.

COLOUR

OPEN — FOR REVIEW TOGETHER

The eight colours below are confirmed. **How they pair — which colour goes on which — is not decided.** An earlier draft proposed darkened values for text; those were not from your palette and have been withdrawn. This section states the measured facts and the three honest options, and nothing more.

The eight



Blue · primary
#3655b3



Yellow · primary
#fdcc0a



Green · support
#2ca01c



Mid blue · support
#0060ff



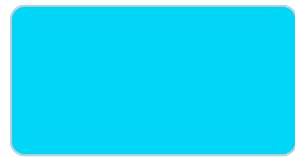
Red · support
#f93946



Purple · accent
#7c3bb0



Pink · accent
#ff24b1



Teal · accent
#00d6f6

The measured facts

Contrast ratios, measured rather than estimated. A ratio of 4.5:1 is the legal minimum for body text; 7:1 is the standard for an audience with reduced vision, which this one is.

COLOUR	AGAINST WHITE	CAN IT CARRY BODY TEXT ON WHITE?
Blue #3655b3	6.76 : 1	Yes at 4.5, no at 7
Purple #7c3bb0	6.75 : 1	Yes at 4.5, no at 7
Mid blue #0060ff	5.10 : 1	Yes at 4.5, no at 7
Red #f93946	3.68 : 1	No
Pink #ff24b1	3.42 : 1	No
Green #2ca01c	3.41 : 1	No
Teal #00d6f6	1.76 : 1	No
Yellow #fdcc0a	1.52 : 1	No

This is not a fault in the palette. These colours are built to be *seen*, which is right for this brand. It only means a decision is needed about what happens when one of them has to carry words.

The one pairing that is certain

INK ON YELLOW — 11.5 : 1

Near-black type on yellow is the strongest pairing the palette contains, and it is already in use in the medical-bills banner. It works on screen and in print, and it is the reason yellow should be treated as a surface rather than a text colour.

The decision to make

OPTION	WHAT IT MEANS	COST
A • Never text on colour	The eight colours are fills, shapes and grounds only. All text is near-black on white, or near-black on yellow.	Strictest and cleanest. No new values at all. Limits headline treatments.
B • Darken where needed	Add a text-safe sibling of each colour, same hue, darkened until it clears the floor.	Adds values that are not in the current palette. This is what the earlier draft did without asking.
C • Accept 4.5 for large text	Keep the floor at 7:1 for body copy, but allow 4.5:1 for headline sizes, which lets blue, purple and mid blue carry large type.	More of the palette becomes usable, with a rule people have to remember.

Nothing below the eight colours above is settled. The next working session decides this, and then the rest of the system inherits it.

TYPOGRAPHY

Two families. **Anton** shouts, once. **DM Sans** does everything else. Both are free, both are on Google Fonts, and this document is set in them.

H1 · ANTON · THE SHOUT · USED ONCE PER SURFACE

DON'T GIVE UP.

H2 · DM SANS 800

Money that is already yours

H3 · DM SANS 700

Step 2 · Call Sheet Classes

LEAD · DM SANS 400

Staying connected shouldn't break the bank. There are programs that lower the cost of phone and internet service.

BODY · DM SANS 400 · THE FLOOR

Lifeline is the main federal program. It gives a monthly discount on phone or internet service through participating providers. You qualify if your income is at or below 135% of the federal poverty guidelines.

QUOTE · DM SANS 500 ITALIC

It was right on time.

META · DM SANS 500 · NEVER SMALLER

Pay Debt & Bills · Phone, Internet & Devices · Page 1 of 2

The rules

- **Anton is for H1 only.** The moment it appears twice on a page it stops being a shout and becomes shouting.

- **Body is 18px minimum on screen, 12pt minimum in print.** Set by the audience, not by taste.
- Line length 45–75 characters.
- Give both fonts a fallback stack with close metrics — exports and emails lose webfonts.

OPEN

The scale above is a proposal, not a decision. It has been tested on a Quick Guide page and an article header but not signed off.

OBJECTS

OPEN — EXPLORATION ONLY

This came from the inspiration round and has not been approved. It is recorded here so the thinking is not lost.

The direction picked from references was **large type with small objects floating around it**, with lots of air. The condition attached to it: the objects must mean something in this community, not be generic startup confetti.

Eight objects were drawn, each naming something real in the member journey:

The question mark	Asking — the whole practice
The heart	From the playing-card suits. Care.
The telephone	The call — who I called, and what they said
The envelope	The answer that arrives
The house	Housing, rent, the roof
The call sheet	Step 2 of the roadmap
The glasses	His. Nobody else's.
The key	The hidden door opens

Proposed behaviour: flat fill, one brand colour each, bold black outline of even weight. Scattered with generous air, rotated a few degrees so they feel dropped rather than placed. Never more than six on a surface, never overlapping the type. They fill the air around the message; they never compete with it.

Also open: whether the question mark should be the universal system icon. In an earlier draft it was used for space logos, badges, callout markers, the banner pattern and the wordmark all at once, which was too much of one device.

ASSET SPECS

Every branded surface in the community, with the size the platform requires.
Taken from the Mighty Networks branding guide.

Network

ASSET	MINIMUM SIZE	WATCH OUT FOR
Network logo	500 × 500	Corners are rounded on crop — keep padding
Primary image / video	1920 × 1080	Responsive; edges crop on other screens
Global header brand	1155 × 245	Sits on the header colour

Spaces

ASSET	MINIMUM SIZE	WATCH OUT FOR
Space logo	500 × 500	Rounded-square crop. Reads small in the sidebar.
Space branding image	1155 × 245	Replaces logo, name and tagline
Space banner — thin	2880 × 150	Colour and pattern only, not detail
Space banner — tall	1560 × 334	For imagery with recognisable content

Landing page

SECTION	IMAGE SIZE
Heading	1920 × 1080
Full-width heading	3840 × 2160
Media	2400 × 1350
Media with text	1200 × 675
Story block	560 × 560
Double story blocks	320 × 320
Feature list icon	80 × 80
Bento box grid	1920 × 1080 — uploaded through the Heading section

Everything else

ASSET	MINIMUM SIZE	TEXT SAFE AREA
Event header	1920 × 1080	—
Event thumbnail	280 × 280	—
Course section / lesson	1920 × 1080	2375 × 1185
Featured plan image	1600 × 900	Renders large when shared
Article header	2560 × 1440	2375 × 1185
Video thumbnail	1600 × 900	1300 × 600
Profile photo	500 × 500	Circle crop
Cover photo	1520 × 860	Crops vertical on mobile
Badges	256 × 256	—
Value graphics	288 × 288	—

Rules that apply to every asset

- **Text safe areas are not optional.** Several assets crop differently by device.

- **The accessibility floor does not relax for banners.** Type sized for a thumbnail must still be legible on a phone.
- **Small assets carry one idea.** Space logos, badges and 80 × 80 icons are seen at a fraction of their exported size. One shape, one colour, no text.
- **The banner pair is a choice of job, not taste.** Thin is for colour and pattern; tall is for imagery with content.

STATUS

An honest account of what is decided and what is not, so nothing gets used as though it were finished.

Settled

The story	Both villains, the stakes, the main character, the guide, the practice, the promise, and the counter-line to the impersonators
Voice	The harvested phrases, how to write, and the never-do list
Vocabulary	The seven roadmap steps and the proper nouns
The character	Three forms and their jobs, the generation rules, proportions and framing
The wardrobe	Three costumes, five rules, and what was tried and rejected
Colour values	The eight hex codes and their measured contrast
Asset specs	Every community surface and its required size

Open

Colour pairings	Which colour goes on which, and how text is handled on colours that cannot carry it. Three options are on the table; none is chosen. <i>This is the next decision.</i>
Typography	The scale is proposed and tested but not signed off
Objects	Exploration only. Eight objects drawn, behaviour proposed, nothing approved.
The question mark as system icon	Over-used in an earlier draft. Needs a deliberate limit.
The wordmark	A LESKO?HELP lockup was drawn from the existing Quick Guide masthead but never confirmed
A Protect costume	Two attempts rejected. May be the wrong question.
Layout & components	Grid, spacing scale and the component set are drafted on canvas but not settled

What was learned the hard way

Recorded because it cost time and should not cost it again:

- The character cannot be generated from a written description. It descends from a picture, always.
- Banning a character's defining features to make them friendlier produces a different person.
- A wide pose in a square frame produces short legs no matter what the prompt says about height.
- An intricate photographic garment print cannot be reconstructed in flat comic style from words.
- Skipping the inspiration and direction steps produces competent, forgettable work. It was skipped here, and it showed.

Where everything lives

<code>.claude/skills/brand-system/</code>	The method — how a brand system is built and applied. Identical in every client repository.
<code>.claude/skills/lesko-brand/</code>	This brand's answers, machine-readable. Loads automatically in any session.
<code>brand/tokens.css</code>	Colour values
<code>brand/ASSET-SPECS.md</code>	Community surface sizes
<code>brand/character/</code>	Reference stills, the generation recipe, the wardrobe
<code>design/</code>	Canvas sources
<code>documents/</code>	This document

NEXT

Decide the colour pairings. Everything else in the visual system inherits that decision, which is why it comes first.